

Manatees ([/'mænətiːz/](#), [family Trichechidae](#), [genus *Trichechus*](#)) are large, fully aquatic, mostly [herbivorous marine mammals](#) sometimes known as **sea cows**. There are three accepted living species of Trichechidae, representing three of the four living species in the order [Sirenia](#): the [Amazonian manatee](#) (*Trichechus inunguis*), the [West Indian manatee](#) (*Trichechus manatus*), and the [West African manatee](#) (*Trichechus senegalensis*). They measure up to 4.0 metres (13 ft 1 in) long, weigh as much as 590 kilograms (1,300 lb),^[2] and have paddle-like tails.

Manatees are [herbivores](#) and eat over 60 different freshwater and saltwater plants. Manatees inhabit the shallow, [marshy](#) coastal areas and rivers of the [Caribbean Sea](#), the [Gulf of Mexico](#), the [Amazon basin](#), and [West Africa](#).

The main causes of death for manatees are human-related issues, such as [habitat destruction](#) and human objects. Their slow-moving, curious nature has led to violent collisions with propeller-driven boats and ships. Some manatees have been found with over 50 scars on them from propeller blades. Natural causes of death include adverse temperatures, predation by crocodiles on young, and disease.